



Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Computers Through The Ages

Not much hair on your chin? Do people poke fun at you for never having braved the times of Windows 3.1? Here's how to show them that even though you haven't been there *or* done that, you still know more.

The Baby: On June 21, 1948, the University of Manchester made its first successful run of a computer program on the Small Scale Experimental Machine, affectionately called the Baby. It was the first machine that had the same basic set-up as the modern computer and could store both data *and* programs in memory. **The IBM 604:** This was an electron-tube based computer that could read and process punch-cards. Its 2x2x1 m frame and a petite 640 kilo weight made it the first commercially available miniature electronic calculator. It ran at 50 KHz and was built out of 1600 vacuum triodes.

The ENIAC: Following the success of The Baby and its successor, the Mark I, researchers developed the ENIAC—the Electrical Numerical Integrator and Computer, which shattered the 2000-tube barrier with its 18,000 vacuum tubes in its 1800 square-foot cabinet. It could add, multiply and calculate square roots, though some claim its real agenda was to take over the world. **The Altair:** In 1975, Popular Electronics magazine began selling the Altair as a kit. Based on the revolutionary Intel 8080A microprocessor, this monster could be picked up for \$397 and required dedicated geek-time to be assembled and finally used. It had 256 bytes of memory, and was programmed in 0s and 1s by flipping switches on its front panel.

So the next time anyone mocks at you for not knowing computers, shoot a few classics at them.

FIVE is a nice number...

OK, we're patting ourselves on the back, but three cheers to the *Digit* team's spirit! We battled two of our worst enemies to have this bonanza issue out. First, the Friday load-shedding; we've also been working weekends as well, and no sir, no AC on weekends! Then, of course, the deadlines—which of course no one met, but the universe unfolds as it should, and things worked out all fine. Except for Ed Deepak's hair having greyed a bit.

It's been raining trips to Singapore: Michael made a mid-month trip for a training program, and the end of the month saw Nimish follow suit for a training program on Vista. They brought back cigarettes for Raaabo and Ram. One pack each. ("Just because I went to Singapore doesn't mean I had money!")

Raaabo, Nimish and Prakash spotted

the deprived-of-the-comfort-of-my-home look while they battled slow Net speeds and late nights to prepare our dual-layer DVD. We arrived at work one morning to find them sprawled senseless under their tables. We had to use an intravenous caffeine drip to wake Raaabo up.

Anup has taken a sabbatical to study for a while, whereas Jyotsna is moving on for good. What had us all in splits was the quick entry and quickest ever exit of an indecisive wannabe *Digit*-ian, a certain Mr Singh. A Thursday morning saw him striding into office and taking up his appointed seat; Friday afternoon saw him gone without a word to anyone! Was it the no-AC-on-Friday thing that scared him off?

And finally, as we turn five, we're already wondering what the next five and more years will see. *Digit* on paper displays perhaps?

DIGIT DIARY

provided you don't share them, and they're for your personal backup purposes. So do backup and pirated DVDs smell different, too?

Another pressing question is, why broadcast the news that sniffer dogs are being used? DVD pirates will now probably coat their wares in pepper to throw the dogs off. So now if your next off-the-street DVD smells of pepper, you know it's been through Stansted Airport!

LEGAL P2P USE

BitTorrent To Deliver Movies

Warner Bros will use BitTorrent's technology to deliver movie downloads, the studio's home entertainment division announced mid-May. Early May, it was alleged that Apple will use the same system to power its upcoming movie download service. Warner will soon make available for download, via BitTorrent, around 200 titles. The content will be available for computer playback only, and will, naturally, be DRM-protected. The DRM technology the service in use will have to

work alongside the BitTorrent system, which splits content into numerous chunks to accelerate delivery. See *How BitTorrent Works*, *Digit* April 2006.

BitTorrent co-founder Ashwin Navin said the company is in talks with other studios, but there was no word on how much the downloads will cost.

In November 2005, BitTorrent had struck a deal with the MPAA to remove links to pirated movie files from its search engine. Was that just to look good? What's the point of one search engine removing links when there are a hundred others that will provide the same links?

We're not attempting an analysis of this move on BitTorrent's part, but there's potential for a comical situation here. If BitTorrent's main site will have a music purchase section and also the free torrent search bar, we could soon be seeing two large buttons on BitTorrent.com's main page:

1. "I'm a regular P2Per. Get on with it—take me to the free movies!"

2. "I'm a God-fearing, law-abiding citizen. Take me to your credit card processing system so I can pay for the movies!"

MARS AND VENUS

Gender Differences Online@Work

Folks always find surveys that reveal gender differences interesting, hence the following: Websense, a Web security and Web filtering productivity software company, recently conducted the 2006 Web@Work Employee survey. Some of the findings are predictable; some are interesting.

First, men are more likely than women to engage in personal Web surfing at work. Now that's probably because women are in general more law-abiding and God-fearing than men, but it's just a thought—please don't write in to tell us otherwise!

As far as the types of sites they visit while at the workplace is concerned, there's a significant difference. Men are 2.3 times more likely to visit sports sites. They're twice as likely to visit investment or stock purchasing sites (naturally, MCPs would say: women don't know how to invest). But here's a surprise: men are 2.5 times more likely